AHLI SWITZLER | CASE STUDY 1

AI-Assisted Sponsorship Campaign for an Independent Publication

I built a three-tool AI workflow to fund a print run nearly double the last one, and caught the tools inventing claims before anything reached a buyer.

THE CHALLENGE

Drinking Buddies is a free illustrated quarterly I founded, funded by brand sponsorship pages and event fees. Every issue sells out, so readership is capped by how many copies sponsors pay for. The goal was to grow the holiday issue from 250 to 400 to 500 copies, about $1,000 to $1,250 per issue, by closing two sponsor pages before a mid-November print deadline.

ROLE AND TOOLS

Solo. Perplexity for prospect research, Claude for messaging and outreach copy, Figma AI for the sponsor one-sheet.

THE PROCESS

I set the tools up as a relay, with my review between every step.

1. Perplexity found brands actively marketing in the region that hadn't sponsored yet. I opened its cited sources and picked the brands myself.
2. Claude wrote key messages for four audiences: new brand reps, returning sponsors, distribution partners, and readers. The first round was accurate and flat. Attaching the publication's media kit as a voice reference fixed it.
3. Claude drafted the cold outreach email from the strongest new-sponsor message.
4. Figma AI laid out the one-sheet. I supplied my own illustrations as style references and corrected the type, color, and figure drawing over four rounds.

WHAT I CAUGHT AND DECIDED

- Figma added claims I never gave it: copies that "vanish within 48 hours," a lead illustrator on a team of one, and 20 distribution points instead of 18. Every one comes off before the sheet reaches a rep.
- Perplexity's timing advice said to lock holiday sponsors by early September, which had already passed. I used what I know about how sponsor budgets follow the fiscal year and moved brands with active Q4 launches to the front of the list.
- I ruled out AI audience segmentation. The buyer pool is small and the print readers leave no data, so firsthand knowledge did that job better.

THE RESULT

A ranked list of nine prospect brands, key messages for four audiences, a ready-to-send outreach email, and a one-sheet checked claim by claim, all tied to a costed funding target. The framework behind it maps to Huang and Rust's (2021) split: mechanical and thinking AI took the research, drafting, and layout, and I kept the relationship work.

THE ONE-SHEET, FIRST AND LAST AI VERSIONS



First version: all-caps type and a stock-style illustration.



Last version after four rounds of my corrections. The invented claims in its copy are the ones flagged above.

> **Assessment: 100/100.** Christina J. Inge, EdD, Harvard Extension School, Digital Marketing and Artificial Intelligence.